



ROUTINE CORRESPONDENCE

Negative
messages

Persuasive
Messages



TODAY'S AGENDA

1

three-step writing process to negative messages.

2

how to effectively use the direct/ indirect approach when conveying negative news.

3

importance of maintaining high standards of ethics in negative messages

4

strategies for sending negative messages on routine business matters.

5

conveying negative organizational news.

6

strategies for sending negative employment-related messages.



Negative messages can have as many as five goals:

- Give the bad news
- Ensure acceptance of the bad news
- Maintain the reader's goodwill
- Maintain the organization's good image
- Minimize or eliminate future correspondence on the matter, as appropriate



GOALS

A yellow and white striped banner with the word "GOALS" in bold black capital letters. A blue arrow points from the bottom of the banner towards the list of goals on the notepad.

STEP 1

Planning a negative message

- Consider your purpose
- Selecting the right medium and channel
- Defining your main idea
- Organization of a negative message

Direct
Approach

Indirect
Approach

STEP 2

Write a negative message

- Writing clearly and sensitively helps take some of the sting out of bad news.
- Protect your audience's pride by using language that conveys respect.

STEP 3

Complete a negative message

-
- Revise your content to make sure everything is clear, complete, and concise.
 - Proof read to eliminate mistakes
 - Be sure to deliver it promptly

DIRECT/ INDIRECT APPROACH

- Do you need to get the reader's attention immediately?
- Does the recipient prefer a direct style of communication?
- How important is this news to the reader?
- Will the bad news come as a shock?

**DIRECT OR INDIRECT
APPROACH?**





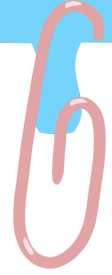
Direct Approach

A negative message using the direct approach:

- opens with the bad news,
- proceeds to the reasons for the situation or the decision,
- ends with a positive statement aimed at maintaining a good relationship with the audience.

**USING DIRECT APPROACH TO
NEGATIVE MESSAGES**





- To some people, it simply means an expression of sympathy that something negative has happened to another person.
- At the other extreme, it means admitting fault and taking responsibility for specific compensations or corrections to atone for the mistake.

**SHOULD YOU APOLOGIZE WHEN
DELIVERING BAD NEWS OR RESPONDING
TO NEGATIVE SITUATIONS?**





- the apology should be delivered by someone whose position in the organization corresponds with the gravity of the situation.
- the apology needs to be real.
- Third, apologies need to be delivered quickly
- media and channel choices are crucial.

CREATING AN EFFECTIVE APOLOGY





- It makes a shorter message
- It allows the audience to reach the main idea of the message in less time.

**ADVANTAGES OF USING
DIRECT APPROACH TO
NEGATIVE MESSAGES**





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March 6, 2018

Dr. Sandra Wofford, President
Whittier Community College
333 Whittier Avenue
Tulsa, OK 74150

Dear Dr. Wofford:

Infotech has been happy to support Whittier Community College in many ways over the years, and we appreciate the opportunities you and your organization provide to so many deserving students. Thank you for considering our grounds for your graduation ceremony on June 3.

We would certainly like to accommodate Whittier as we have in years past, but our companywide sales meetings will be held this year during the weeks of May 29 and June 5. With more than 200 sales representatives and their families from around the world joining us, activities will be taking place throughout our facility.

My assistant, Robert Seagers, suggests you contact the Municipal Botanical Gardens as a possible graduation site. He recommends calling Jerry Kane, director of public relations.

We remain firm in our commitment to you, President Wofford, and to the fine students you represent. Through our internship program, academic research grants, and other initiatives, we will continue to be a strong corporate partner to Whittier College and will support your efforts as you move forward.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in blue ink that reads 'May Yee Kwan'.

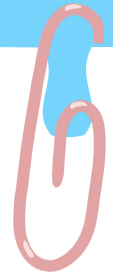
May Yee Kwan
Public Relations Director

→ The buffer eases the recipient into the message by demonstrating respect and recapping the request.

→ Kwan suggests an alternative, showing that she cares about the college and has given the matter some thought.

← She provides a meaningful reason for the negative response, without apologizing (because the company is not at fault).

← Her close emphasizes the importance of the relationship and the company's continuing commitment.



Indirect Approach

A negative message using the indirect approach:

- opens with a buffer
- proceeds to the reasons and additional information
- Clear statement of the bad news
- Closing with a respectful note.

**USING INDIRECT APPROACH
TO NEGATIVE MESSAGES**



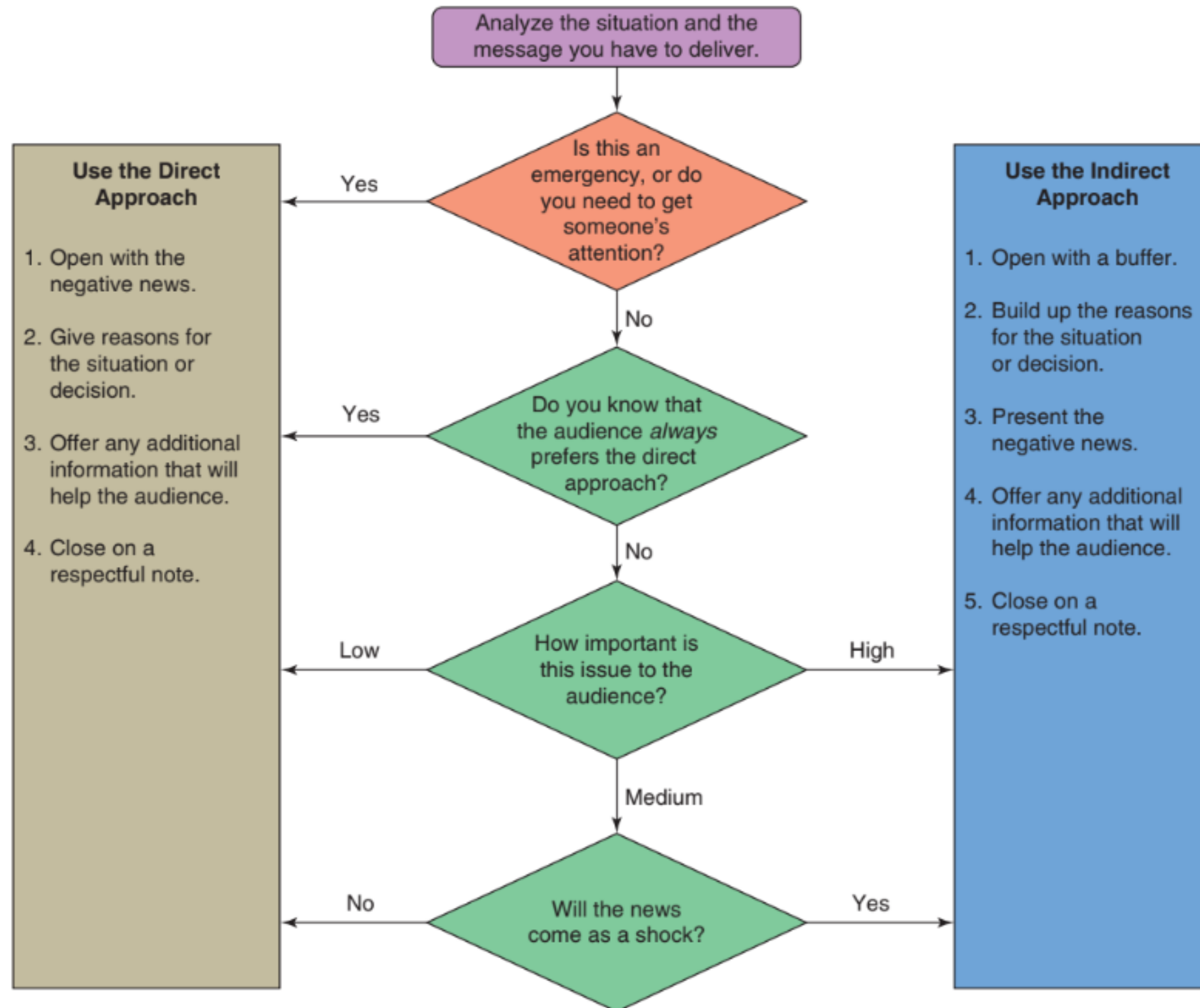


Figure 11.2 Choosing the Direct or Indirect Approach

Following this decision tree will help you decide whether the direct or indirect approach is better in a given situation. Of course, use your best judgment as well. Your relationship with the audience, for example, could affect your choice of approaches.

CHECKLIST



Creating Negative Messages

A. Choose the better approach.

- Consider using the direct approach when the audience is aware of the possibility of negative news, when the reader is not emotionally involved in the message, when you know that the reader would prefer the bad news first, when you know that firmness is necessary, and when you want to discourage a response.
- Consider using the indirect approach when the news is likely to come as a shock or surprise, when your audience has a high emotional investment in the outcome, and when you want to maintain a good relationship with the audience.

B. For the indirect approach, open with an effective buffer.

- Establish common ground with the audience.
- Validate the request, if you are responding to one.
- Don't trivialize the reader's concerns.
- Don't mislead the reader into thinking the coming news might be positive.

C. Provide reasons and additional information.

- Explain why the news is negative.
- Adjust the amount of detail to fit the situation and the audience.

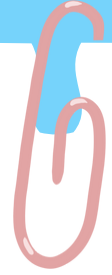
- Avoid explanations when the reasons are confidential, excessively complicated, or irrelevant to the reader.
- If appropriate, state how you plan to correct or respond to the negative news.
- Seek the advice of company lawyers if you're unsure what to say.

D. Clearly state the bad news.

- State the bad news as positively as possible, using tactful wording.
- To help protect readers' feelings, deemphasize the bad news by minimizing the space devoted to it, subordinating it, or embedding it.
- If your response might change in the future if circumstances change, explain the conditions to the reader.
- Emphasize what you can do or have done rather than what you can't or won't do.

E. Close on a respectful note.

- Express best wishes without being falsely positive.
- Suggest actions readers might take, if appropriate, and provide them with necessary information.
- Encourage further communication only if you're willing to discuss the situation further.



- Making negative announcements on routine business matters
- Rejecting suggestions and proposals
- Refusing routine requests
- Handling bad news about transactions
- Refusing claims and requests for adjustment.

**NEGATIVE MESSAGES IN ROUTINE
BUSINESS MATTERS**



Activity

One of your employee's has proposed the idea on the behalf of Operations Department to upgrade the office desktops with macbooks. Write an email to the concerned employee, rejecting the proposal by mentioning the financial restrictions and the response of the concerned departments on the given proposal.

Godfrey uses the buffer to convey the good news.

These two sentences imply the forthcoming bad news by telling the reader what's being done, not what can't be done.

The body and close foster a positive on going relationship by inviting inquiries and reminding the customer of a key benefit.

She includes helpful contact information.

Subject: Order #REC-O-7814: Status update

Dear Dr. Fawnworth:

Thank you for your recent order. The Special Edition recliner with the customized leather trim you requested is being shipped today.

The roll-around ottoman has proved to be one of our most popular items. Even though we've doubled production of this model, we still have a slight order backlog. Your ottoman will be shipped no later than November 15 and will arrive in plenty of time for the Thanksgiving holiday.

If you have any questions about your new furniture, please don't hesitate to discuss them with me (my email and phone are listed below). Like all La-Z-Boy products, your recliner and ottoman carry a lifetime guarantee.

By the way, we continue to expand the Special Edition line. If at some point you would like to complement your new recliner and ottoman with other coordinating pieces, I would be happy to discuss the latest fabrics and design options. Of course, you can always view the newest models online at www.la-z-boy.com.

Cordially,
Suzanne Godfrey
Manager, Custom Designs
sgodfrey@la-z-boy.com
(616) 358-2899

She explains the delay and immediately cushions bad news with a pledge to ship by a definite time.

This resale information encourages future purchasing, but in a way that addresses the customer's needs, not La-Z-Boy's.

Figure 11.4 Effective Negative Message Regarding a Transaction

This message, which is a combination of good and bad news, uses the indirect approach—with the good news serving as a buffer for the bad news. In this case the customer wasn't promised delivery by a certain date, so the writer simply informs the customer when to expect the rest of the order. The writer also takes steps to repair the relationship and encourage future business with her firm.



- Communicating under normal circumstance.
- Responding to negative news on social media (engage/ respond/ monitor/ respond)
- Communicating in crisis

**SENDING NEGATIVE
ORGANIZATIONAL NEWS**





- Refusing requests for employee references and recommendations
- Refusing social networking recommendation requests
- Rejecting job applications
- Giving performance reviews
- Terminating employees

**SENDING NEGATIVE
EMPLOYMENT MESSAGES**





PERSUASIVE MESSAGES

standing
are as
and
competitors
work.



1

Three step writing process

2

Strategy for writing developing persuasive messages

3

Strategy for writing developing sales and marketing messages

4

Summary and Action Items

STEP 1

Planning a persuasive message

-
- Analyzing the situation
 - Gathering information
 - Selecting the right media and channels
 - Organizing the information

STEP 2

Writing a persuasive message

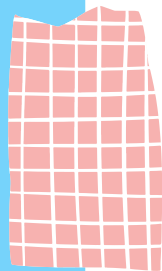
Use these techniques:

- Use simple language to avoid suspicions of fantastic claims and emotional manipulation.
- Provide objective evidence for the claims and promises you make.
- Identify your information sources.
- Establish common ground by emphasizing beliefs, attitudes, and experiences you have in common with the audience.
- Be objective and present fair and logical arguments.
- Display your willingness to keep your audience's best interests at heart.
- Persuade with logic, evidence, and compelling narratives, rather than trying to coerce with high-pressure, "hard sell" tactics.
- Whenever possible, try to build your credibility before you present a major proposal or ask for a major decision. That way, audiences don't have to evaluate both you and your message at the same time.

STEP 3

Completing persuasive message

Evaluate your content,
try to judge your argument objectively and
do not overestimate your credibility.



DEVELOPING PERSUASIVE BUSINESS MESSAGES

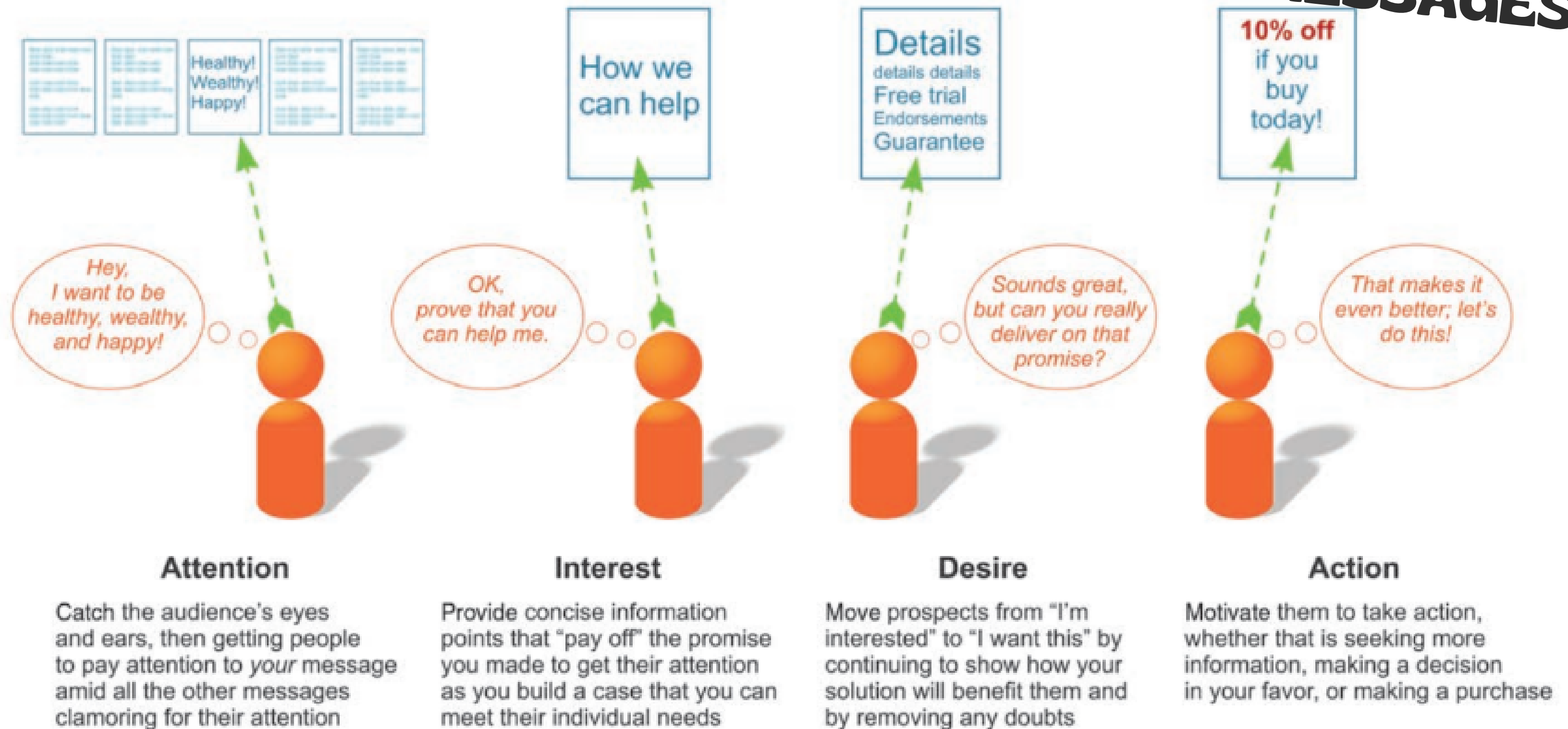


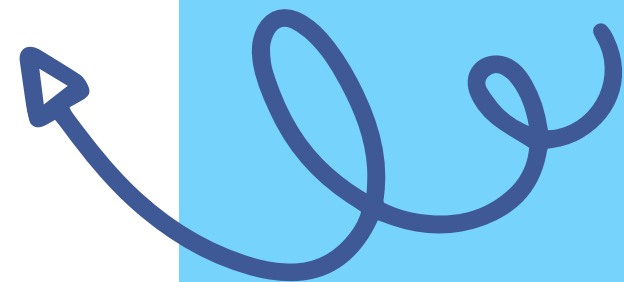
Figure 12.2 The AIDA Model for Persuasive Messages

With the AIDA model, you craft one or more messages to move recipients through the four stages of attention, interest, desire, and action. The model works well for both persuasive business messages (such as persuading your manager to fund a new project) and marketing and sales messages.



- Assessing audience needs
- Analyzing your competition
- Determining key selling points
- Anticipating purchase objectives

**DEVELOPING
MARKETING/SALES
MESSAGES**



- 
- Facilitate community building
 - Listen at least as much as you talk
 - Initiate and respond to conversations
 - Provide information that people want
 - Identify and support your champions
 - Be real
 - Integrate AIDA

**WRITING PERSUASIVE
MESSAGES FOR SOCIAL
MEDIA**

